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# China Internet & New Media

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EQUITY: INTERNET & NEW MEDIA

## Takeaways from Together AI expert call

### Chinese open-weight flash models gain ground overseas thanks to superior cost-capability performance

We recently interacted with an expert from Together AI (unlisted), a leading overseas AI infrastructure company specializing in inference services and the deployment of AI models. According to the expert, Chinese open-weight models are gaining traction overseas, supported by superior cost-capability performance, especially with light-weight models like DeepSeek 4.1 Flash being one of the most popular models. The expert believes this kind of light-weight models developed by Chinese AI labs are increasingly being applied to routine tasks by overseas users thanks to their sufficient capabilities while at lower inference costs. According to the expert, the growing usage demands for Chinese open-weight models create opportunities for third-party inference providers such as Together AI. The expert mentioned that Together AI typically hosts Chinese open-weight models on its overseas infrastructure independently, enabling international customers, particularly enterprises with strict data residency and compliance requirements, to access these models through locally hosted APIs. Additionally, as per the expert, Together AI also provides dedicated overseas inference capacity to Chinese AI labs, helping them alleviate computing resources constraints and scale global API services without substantial upfront infrastructure investment.

The expert believes as API pricing competition intensifies, inference optimization, particularly improvements in GPU utilization and token throughput, will become increasingly important for cost competitiveness and margin protection. DeepSeek (unlisted), in particular, has demonstrated strong capabilities in inference engineering, enabling higher GPU utilization and token throughput, according to the expert. The expert noted that while DeepSeek has open-sourced its inference framework, DeepInfer, replicating its production-level efficiency remains challenging, given the complexity of system-level optimization and infrastructure integration. According to the expert, DeepSeek is likely to retain a competitive edge in inference optimization over the foreseeable future, despite growing adoption of its open-source technologies by third-party providers.

The expert noted China's recently proposed AI technology export controls appear broadly supportive of open-source model's global scalability, while introducing greater oversight of core technology transfers. According to the expert, neither Together AI's independent hosting of Chinese open-weight models nor its provision of overseas inference capacity to Chinese model developers has been materially disrupted by recent regulatory developments. Nevertheless, dedicated inference partnerships involve more direct commercial and business relationships with Chinese AI labs and may face greater regulatory scrutiny, potentially greater exposure to changes in technology export controls or cross-border computing resource usage restrictions, as per the expert.

**Chinese open-weight models, especially the flash models gain traction overseas**

According to the expert, Chinese models have established a leading position in the overseas open-weight model market observed by the expert, supported by the compelling combination of competitive capabilities and cost efficiency when compared to other overseas open-weight models. Especially, the expert noted that DeepSeek 4.1 Flash has become one of the most popular models on the Together AI platform – even more than the open-weight flagship models – as it can offer sufficient capabilities for routine tasks at substantially lower inference costs than larger flagship models. The growing adoption of Flash models is reshaping competition among Chinese AI labs in overseas markets. Nevertheless, the expert believes scaling laws continue to support further advances in model intelligence. Chinese AI labs are therefore likely to pursue a dual-track strategy, i.e., advancing the frontier of model intelligence while translating these technological gains


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into more cost-efficient models for large-scale commercial applications, as per the expert.

Model performance and pricing remain the primary considerations for overseas adoption. According to the expert, developers typically prioritize model capabilities, inference speed and overall usage costs when selecting LLMs. For larger enterprise customers, additional considerations, including data privacy, data center location and regulatory compliance, can also influence model selection and deployment decisions, the expert noted.

### Agentic workloads emerge as a structural driver of token demand

The expert observed a growing transition in overseas model usage from traditional conversational applications toward agent-based workflows. Unlike conventional chat interactions, agent tasks frequently involve extended context windows and multiple rounds of reasoning, etc. These workloads, according to the expert, consume significantly more tokens per task, potentially supporting sustained growth in inference demand. The expert also highlighted growing interest in personal AI agents, suggesting that open-weight model adoption is expanding beyond coding into broader productivity and automation use cases as model capabilities improve.

### Together AI benefits from Chinese developers' overseas compute demand

Together AI offers two primary inference services: serverless inference, which hosts open-weight models independently and charges customers on token consumption, and dedicated inference, which provides reserved GPU capacity and customized deployment environments. According to the expert, dedicated inference accounts for a substantially larger share of its inference business. The expert further observed that compared with serverless APIs, which primarily serve developers and smaller customers, dedicated inference mainly caters to larger enterprise customers and model developers with substantial inference demand.

The expert noted that some leading Chinese model developers are cooperating with Together AI to address GPU capacity constraints while prioritizing internal computing resources for model training and development. Under such cooperation, Together AI provides computing infrastructure and model-serving capabilities, while model developers retain customer relationships and API monetization. We believe such partnerships offer a relatively asset-light approach for Chinese AI labs to scaling inference capacity.

Together AI also participates in GPU cluster and data center infrastructure delivery, which the expert suggested could represent its largest revenue contributor, albeit at lower gross margins than inference services.

### Inference optimization becomes a key competitive differentiator

The expert emphasized that inference economics depend not only on GPU costs but also on token throughput and monetization per GPU-hour. In this context, the expert highlighted DeepSeek's publicly released inference framework, DeepInfer, which can improve resource utilization and inference throughput. The expert believes such advances could have important implications for the broader inference infrastructure ecosystem. According to the expert, Together AI is experimenting with similar technologies and adapting them to its own GPU configurations and production environments. The expert noted that although other players can adopt the aforementioned publicly released optimization techniques, replicating DeepSeek's production-level efficiency remains challenging. The expert believes DeepSeek will still retain an advantage in certain aspects of inference engineering in a foreseeable future.

### Geopolitical risks on cross-border inference deployment

The expert believes that geopolitical risks associated with overseas deployment of Chinese models should be assessed separately across different business models. For serverless hosting of publicly available open-weight models, the expert observed that immediate commercial risks appear relatively minimal, as third-party platforms can independently deploy publicly released model weights, subject to applicable licensing and regulations. Dedicated inference arrangements with Chinese model developers, however, involve more direct commercial relationships and potentially greater exposure to changes in technology export controls or cross-border computing restrictions, the expert noted. While the expert indicated that existing dedicated inference cooperation with certain Chinese AI labs had not been materially disrupted by regulatory developments as of the interview.

# Appendix A-1

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